

**Exploring Psychological, Social and Legal Implications of Image-Based Sexual Abuse
(IBSA) Through Posts on Reddit: Literature Review**

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Image based sexual abuse, or IBSA, is a recently coined term that refers to a form of sexual abuse that involves sharing, threatening to share or creating intimate pictures or videos of another individual without consent. It is a form of technology-facilitated violence that has become particularly significant as a result of AI deepfakes and videos. It has significant impacts on the survivors' mental and social lives that last for many years, requiring immense effort to heal from. However, it is difficult to get a good picture of what this experience looks like in a research setting, as talking about IBSA can be traumatic and requires breaking through social stigma. This leaves us with a question: How can we take a closer, unfiltered look at the effects of IBSA on survivors and what motivates perpetrators to initiate IBSA? In our qualitative excursion, we have used Reddit along with previously recorded case studies to answer these questions.

Rationale for Reddit as a Source

Reddit is a widely used online platform for users to post their ideas, experiences, thoughts and everything else. It provides us with many benefits such as anonymity, pseudonymity and sub-reddits that allow us to access posts talking about similar experiences. This is entirely different from a qualitative interview where stigmas, fear of judgment and biases colour the kind of responses the researcher may get. This allows us to access honest and detailed personal experiences. Previous studies have elucidated the benefits of anonymity and reducing risks of social evaluation (Moreno et al, 2011). This is particularly relevant here as survivors are concerned about reputational harm, victim-blaming and other implications. Morini et al. (2025) show that Reddit discussions reduce social desirability bias and enable access to reliable personal information.

Another benefit of using Reddit is the access we get to a diverse population of survivors from various countries and cultures. This provides an opportunity to explore how different contexts may affect how IBSA persists in society. Furthermore, the users can post about their experiences whenever they feel comfortable and at their own pace, without any pressure. Lastly, Reddit allows us to observe group interactions and discussions in these posts. Survivors may sometimes seek advice, comfort or similar experiences from other users. This community-based dialogue that happens on Reddit gives us additional insights into coping strategies, social attitudes and beliefs around IBSA. This helps highlight important themes, misconceptions or gaps in social and institutional support systems. Thus, Reddit can be a useful source in analysing sensitive information. However, we weren't able to exploit it completely due to time and resource constraints.

Previous Literature

Henry and Powell (2018) define IBSA as the “taking, creation, or distribution of a nude or sexual image or video of another person without their consent”. This is an umbrella term that covers revenge porn, sextortion and other common terms referring to similar forms of sexual abuse.

Research shows that IBSA is widespread, especially in digital relationships. A study across the UK, Australia, and New Zealand found that 17.5% of participants had engaged in IBSA, with 15.8% taking nonconsensual videos or images, 10.6% sharing them, and 8.8% threatening to share them (Powell et al, 2022). This illustrates that normal and common sexual practices involve abusive power dynamics and sometimes coercion. We must also talk about the lack of legal recognition and repercussions for IBSA. Though some jurisdictions criminalise

IBSA specifically, others have to rely on civil law or other provisions in the law, which leads to inconsistencies. This raises an additional barrier for survivors to raise a legal complaint in these cases.

It is also important to note that IBSA is a gendered form of violence. It disproportionately targets women and queer individuals (Bates, 2017). This shows us that IBSA is not just a reflection of individual motives but the larger patriarchal culture of our society. We must view IBSA as a form of maintaining coercive control rather than just an act of harm.

This aligns with the objectification theory (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997), which argues that women are reduced to visual objects for sexual gratification in certain cases. When intimate images or videos are leaked, the survivor's identity is compromised, and they are portrayed as a sexual object. This leads to immense social backlash but also internal shame and psychological distress.

Psychological Impacts on Survivors

The psychological impact of IBSA is intense and long-lasting. Survivors have similar trauma responses to victims of other types of sexual violence. Hellevik et al (2025) say survivors tend to report post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) like symptoms such as intrusive imagery, avoidance behaviour, hypervigilance, and nightmares. The permanence of images online makes it worse since survivors feel a continuous violation, and not a single incident from the past.

Anxiety, depression, and suicidal thoughts are also prevalent among survivors. Schmidt et al. (2024) reported significantly elevated anxiety and depressive symptoms in IBSA survivors compared to control samples. The inability to regulate or do anything about their explicit media

circulating, together with the victim blaming, causes chronic psychological stress. Most survivors withdraw from social networks and internet platforms, which increases feelings of loneliness and shame (Powell et al, 2020).

These experiences can be explained through different psychological models. Cognitive appraisal theory (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984) helps to understand how survivors appraise the threat of IBSA. Survivors tend to appraise the spreading of their images as catastrophic to reputation, identity, and safety and thereby induce increased stress responses. Additionally, learned helplessness theory (Seligman, 1975) can account for why some survivors bear long-term depressive symptoms. The belief that one is powerless and cannot prevent further damage to reputation induces helplessness. This cognitive effect tends to generalise to other areas of life, which then strengthens depressive thoughts and hopelessness.

Labelling theory (Link & Phelan, 2001) also explains how stigma becomes a factor in the survivor's identity formation. Being constantly labelled as a "victim" of IBSA could induce internalised shame because the survivors expect to be stigmatised as being promiscuous or irresponsible, or even sexually shamed. Labels can change one's self-concept and limit their social interaction. Survivors might isolate themselves from both online and offline communities to escape stigma, hence perpetuating isolation.

Importantly, IBSA survivors' accounts of their experiences make it clear that distress is not necessarily created by the circulation of images but also by the reactions of society. Trivialization of harm, victim-blaming, and institutional failure to provide support add to the trauma. These results indicate that IBSA is both a structural and individual problem, as cultural scripts of sexuality converge with technological growth/ convenience to enable victimisation.

Motivations of Perpetrators

The perpetrators' motivations for IBSA are complex, as they depend on context and influence each other. These motivations encompass power, psychological justifications, and digital disinhibition. Perpetrators are found to usually be motivated by interests such as a heightened sex drive or the need for emotional self-regulation. In addition, personal histories such as trauma in childhood, tendencies toward sensation seeking, or the consumption of drugs and pornography can further facilitate such crimes. Beyond individual factors, situational or contextual factors also play a role. The availability and easy accessibility of technological tools, coupled with the perceived security and anonymity of the digital environment, create conditions in which perpetrators feel confident in committing IBSA (Reinicke, 2025).

Offenders often utilize cognitive techniques that enable them to rationalize or neutralize their destructive behavior. Neutralization theory (Sykes & Matza, 1957) explains how offenders utilize denial of harm ("it's just a joke"), denial of the victim ("they deserved it"), and appeal to higher loyalties ("everyone shares images") in order to lower feelings of guilt. Such excuses are frequently seen within online communities where IBSA is trivialised or normalised.

The contribution of online platforms cannot be overemphasised. Suler's (2004) online disinhibition effect theory describes how anonymity, invisibility, and lack of accountability diminish self-regulation, leading perpetrators to commit behaviours they would not commit offline, in face-to-face interactions. Additionally, freedom from immediate social ramifications promotes such behaviour and provides confidence for perpetrators to share nonconsensual media.

The behavior of these aggressors can also be explained by social learning theory (Bandura, 1977). Witnessing peers or internet forums that tolerate IBSA may internalise and

solidify abusive habits. When aggressors observe others committing IBSA without repercussions or even receiving social approval in some cases, they will more likely copy the action. This is what makes the cultural aspect of IBSA stand out, with internet platforms becoming incubators for harmful practices.

Lastly, routine activity theory (Cohen & Felson, 1979) offers a criminological explanation. The interaction of motivated offenders, available digital targets, and ineffective guardianship (e.g., lax legal enforcement or ineffective platform moderation) presents fertile ground for IBSA. Offenders act not just from psychological motives but also because technological and social milieus enable such acts.

Conclusion

This review indicates that IBSA is a multifaceted phenomenon that is difficult to trace to a single cause or issue. It lies at the intersection between technology, psychology, social power structures and law. Survivors experience intense psychological damage, such as trauma, anxiety, depression, shame, and social withdrawal, which can be accounted for through theories like cognitive appraisal theory, learned helplessness, and labelling theory. The motivations of offenders also vary, from revenge, social capital and sometimes even boredom.

We must investigate both the structural and individual aspects of IBSA. Survivors' accounts signify the necessity of strong psychological support, legal safeguards, and cultural shifts, while understanding perpetrators' motives explains the need to intervene in both individual mentalities and large, overarching digital spaces. Through the analysis of Reddit testimonies in our project, we hope to make a unique contribution in documenting lived experiences that

manifest these dynamics in everyday settings. This synthesis of survivor accounts and psychological theory, therefore, provides a more holistic and enriching understanding of IBSA.

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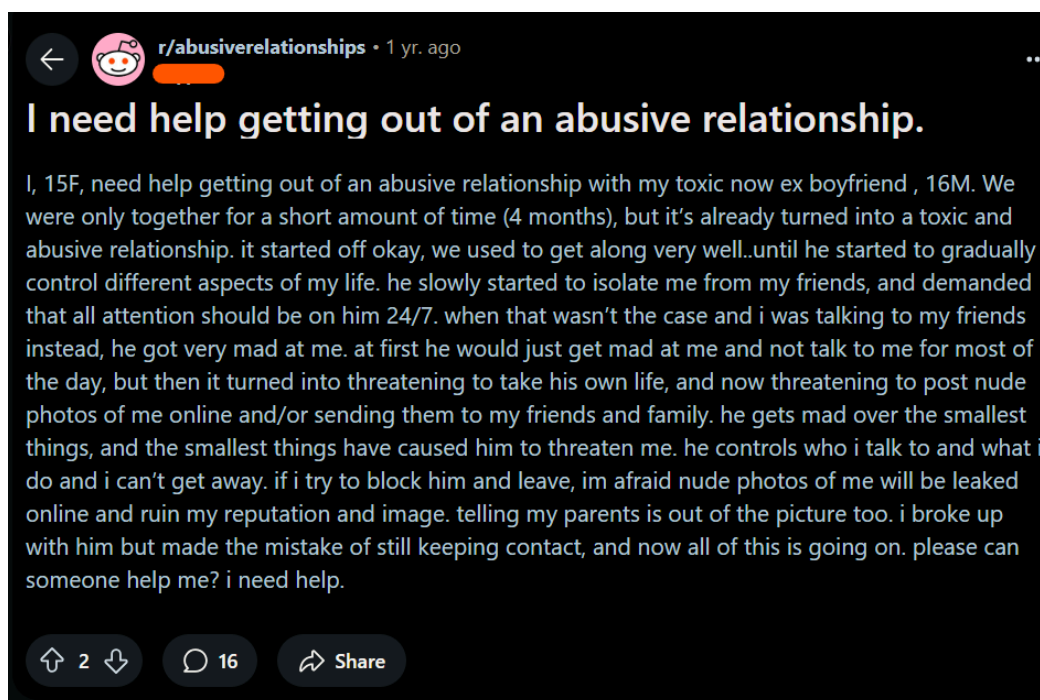
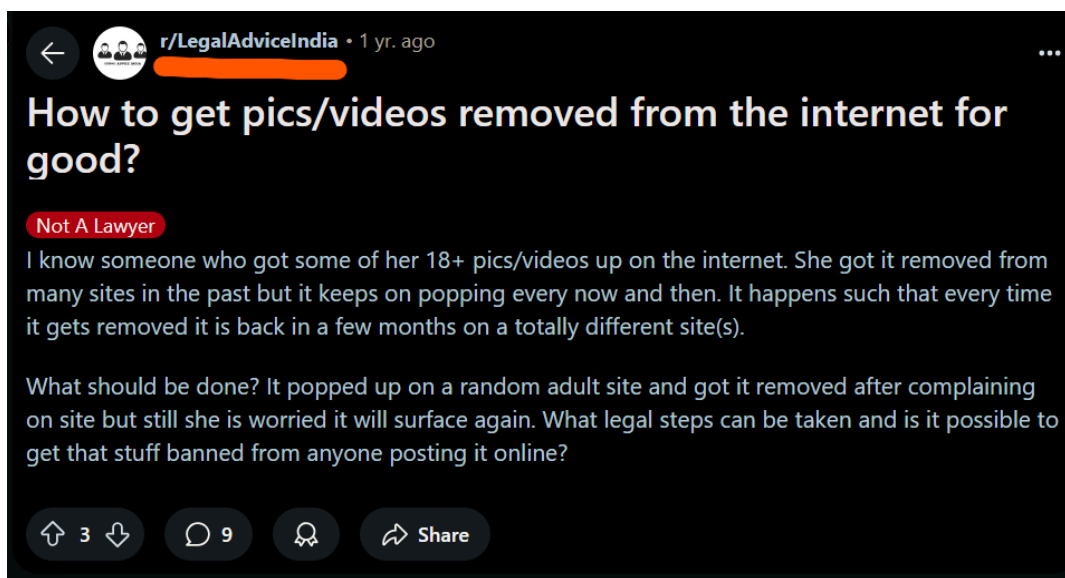
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Appendix

Reddit Posts Used in the Project





r/TrueOffMyChest • 9 mo. ago



I'm a Image based sexual abuse victim and it's created an insane knock on effect

I don't even know where to start, I'm famous in multiple countries. The non consent sexual imagery on me and narratives spread by the original abuser must be so mortifying, that nobody will ever show me, or my family and friends, but really enjoy the storylines of all of it, It's all shared in non public groups on Facebook, discord servers etc but has somehow spread to a massive audience in multiple countries.

Since then random people began to get off on adding to legend, people pretending I'd slept with them. Nieghbours pretending salacious gossip, Odd men trying it on with me, in the hope of getting some "content" they can post for attention. Whether that's just doctored texts or voice recording to try and create something sensational to share in these groups. I'm not even sure if they're getting ad revenue from these posts or if it's just for the attention they get.

The weirdest thing about all this, is it should be obvious from my perspective that a lot of this is fake, horrendously illegally made (it's an actual sex offence to even share any imagery like this which haunts my dreams with how many people are now involved in this), that when people make content on someone like that, it's likely to be egregiously false in one way or another. And I can't get my head around how it's not seen as pathetic and wierd to do it. But people apparently feel like legends doing this stuff to me. Which is hard to get your head around.

This whole situation has ruined my life. But the people sharing this stuff and enjoying content seem completely oblivious to the clearly devastating effects this will have on someone's life and act like the effects of this are just my odd personality: "she doesn't leave her house aswell", "she's socially akward and looks like shit, omg yes" . "Wierd people get obsessed with her" It's like living in southpark episode. Mixed with the twilight zone "imagine a world where your world famous for content you've never made and can't get access to see"

I can't joke about anything, or have deep conversations for fear a conversations somehow being recorded and someone will clip a part of the conversation out of context to make it sensational. The irony of all of this mega slag image people love to curate online about me, is I can't feel comfortable to have a sexual relationship with anyone, because honestly at this point, it feels like even if someone where to love me, the pull of the attention they'd get posting sensationally about me, might be stronger. Also how distrustworthy and amazingly good at lieing people who post stuff like this are, is something I'll probably never be able to predict. Also tbh I'd feel a lot of guilt dragging some poor innocent bloke into this attention too.

It irritates me how much people get off on the attention of posting about me. But in reality I should one day be in the power position to set the record straight, because its me people are obsessed with right? Hopefully get some genuine identity back. Because the strange thing is, I'm a pretty open book. But I guess people prefer the books re-written or chopped up by others.

I hate being in the lime light. But I need to learn to embrace it. And do my own PR to end this. The issue is, how much will these odd balls dieing for 5 mins of attention, try to ruin my image to keep a monopoly on posting my "information", before I suck it up and start actually putting myself out there.

(I'm aware of some of the content people find incredibly interesting, and the actual reality of it is so deliciously ironic)

In the meantime I'm just going to sound completely insane trying to explain my situation to anyone dating.

 Archived post. New comments cannot be posted and votes cannot be cast.

 11

 13
 Share



r/Scams • 1 yr. ago



Person sent me fake nudes of myself and my sister?

Is this a scam?

He messaged me back in April on instagram and I ignored it, obviously looked like a fake account, 0 posts, no mutuals, 20 followers and following over 1000 people (couldn't see who as page is private). He then messaged the company I work for today asking if they could get me to check my messages as there was an urgent family matter. I did message him back and ask why the hell he would message the place I work??

He told me he had nude photos of my sister and I, I told him to prove it and he sent through a photo I have posted publicly that is NOT NAKED but it has been edited (AI or photoshop, not sure) to take my clothes off. It's laughable. Reverse image search pulls up nothing. The photo of my sister in reverse image search comes up with an OnlyFans model we have never heard of, and just has her face edited onto the body (which does look convincing, but obviously is fake too).

He told me he had been sent these from somebody "pretending to be your mum and then your dad/step dad" (wtf?) in a cam girls chat. Sent me a screenshot of the chat and it happened 2 hours in the future according to the screenshot so I think THAT was faked too, especially since he first messaged me about this in April so shouldn't the screenshot have said April? Imao

ANYWAY I told him I don't care that those photos exist, reported him for sexual exploitation, took screenshots of his page to warn my family and friends about it and blocked him, as did my sister.

So he never even got a chance to ask for money or anything, and I can't find the fakes of me and my sister anywhere on the internet only right from his chat, so I don't know if it was a scam?? Would he have eventually asked for money? I don't know why he thought we would care that he has FAKE photos when we obviously have the real photos our faces have been edited from?

I can only find sextortion stuff but these were NOT real photos and we don't know who the fuck this guy is at all. So it wasn't really sextortion? Maybe it was an attempt at it but I tried to find similar posts and could only find posts with real people sending real nude photos.

Just wondering if anyone knows what the hell just went on lol, both our partners and families are aware and have seen the "fakes" and the real photos from us so all is good there!



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92

59



Share



r/TwoXChromosomes • 3 yr. ago



Being a Victim of Image-Based Sexual Abuse (Revenge Porn) + Trying to find Justice / Healing

Support | Trigger

Myself (Female, 19) Ex-boyfriend (Male, 20) - I'll try to keep this as short as possible, but there's a lot. In 2021, I had a >year LDR with a guy with whom I had been friends for a few years prior in a mutual friend group. I was in a bad place following a breakup when we began dating, and at the time, it just felt really nice to not be alone. Our relationship was very relaxed and most of the time we just chatted on voice calls, watched things together, or played games. Considering the distant nature of our relationship and the particularly high sex drive of my partner, many nudes (face and no face) were exchanged, as well as us participating in video chats of sexual nature. I felt okay to do this because of how long I'd known him, and how trusting I actually felt of him. Our relationship was really quite loving, and I was given no reason to think these images would be used against me at some point. Not to mention that face and no-face nude photos and videos were sent by him as well.

To summarize, I started to feel "off" about our relationship, seeing newly uncovered anger issues of his and gradually seeing more of his unkind nature towards people as a whole. Additionally, to be frank, he was a bit of a bum. With him holding no job or ambition to finish school, I started to come out of the fog and realize I did not see a viable future with this person. So, I broke up with him. He found all of my reasons for wanting to leave invalid and manipulated me into sticking around as his "therapist" for a bit due to suicide/self-harm threats. At one point, he actually sent videos of him cutting himself, stating that he wanted me to hurt the way he was. He began to seriously cyberstalk me as I gradually was blocking him on social media/gaming platforms. All of this angered him, and eventually, he turned to using mutual friends to stalk my activity/status. This turned into him cultivating a delusion that I was seeing someone new and found the most creative ways to send me hate messages. Calling me a slut, telling me I must "get off" on toying with guys' emotions, and eventually threatening to expose my nude content to friends, family, coworkers, etc.

I would learn a bit later that he had actually **already** posted nude photos and videos (with my face and full name) to a few porn sites about a month prior to the threat. During this time, he also attempted to hack/log in to various social media accounts of mine. A little while after, that all wasn't enough for him, so he created a burner account to add family, friends, and coworkers of mine to which he DM'd nude photos of me. Thankfully, the only ones who ended up opening them were two female coworkers of mine who immediately notified me/were extremely supportive. I found out about the porn site due to a random individual in my state messaging me on Facebook asking me if I had a profile on that porn site. I found that the profile had been up for 3 months, with around a couple thousand subscribers and more so total views. Not to mention, he had apparently been direct messaging users on the sites impersonating me, telling them details about me and acting interested in them.

I was able to get the porn site to remove the profile entirely within a day after reporting it and submitted link removal requests to Google to clean up the remaining crumbs. All in all, a hugely traumatic experience for me, but life goes on. My friends, family, and coworkers were extremely supportive and to my knowledge, nothing else exists of me out on the internet. Revenge porn is illegal in my state and his. When I found out about it all, I submitted various police reports, got an attorney, and got the ball rolling on a criminal case against him. Here's to hoping that law enforcement comes through and he faces consequences for his sick actions. These traumatic events have left me feeling paranoid, anxious, and as though my body has no value. I don't like to admit feeling this way, as I feel I'm letting him "win" in a sense. But the effects are very real, and I can only hope that with time and therapy, I can regain a sense of bodily value and esteem.

Thank you for listening to my story, and any words of encouragement would be highly appreciated. My heart goes out to any who has experienced something similar. I am sick of image-based sexual abuse victims being told they just shouldn't have sent the photos. Most people have sent nude photos, and with LDRs becoming more viable every day, it is one of the few ways those individuals can participate sexually with one another. One never goes into a relationship expecting to be betrayed at the end of it. We need to stop blaming the victims and realize the fault lies only with the attacker. I am ecstatic to see that almost all 50 states in the U.S. have some sort of revenge porn laws in place nowadays, however, this does little to remedy the damage it can do to the soul.



Archived post. New comments cannot be posted and votes cannot be cast.



7



8



Share

Revenge porn is why I never had kids. Thank you to whoever did it to me.

PERSONAL

I put off having kids for years and remained undecided due to nudes of me being shared over and over again starting 15 years ago and never stopping. On anonib, 4chan, and facebook. I am 36 now and it started when I was in my early 20s. They were even uploaded anonymously to my relative who passed away's memorial website. They were constantly sent anonymously to any acquaintance, co-worker, friend or boyfriend. I never did find out who it was but I do have my suspicions. (They were taken from my boyfriend, it's a long story. It was either a friend, acquaintance, or stranger) I did want kids but I had horrible thoughts of having a child and them growing up and finding my pictures or being sent my pictures or their classmates somehow getting them and them being teased over it. I was also afraid my child may hate me and have no respect for me as their mother because of my pictures. I was harrassed at my job and even had my car vandalized so I was terrified of what would happen if I had a child. At one point screenshots of my facebook including a photo of me holding my baby nephew were posted so I put off having kids, remained on the fence, and I had 3 abortions. I did want kids very badly at one point, and for all the wrong reasons. So I wouldn't be alone, so I could prove that I would be a better mother than my mother, and so I would have someone to love me. All very selfish reasons that only cater to myself and not the child. As time went on and I got to know myself better, matured, and I got to understand the capacity and weight of what having a child is like, I decided firmly at age 33 that I did not want to have kids. It was the best decision and if it were not for those pictures of me being shared, I probably would have had kids 10 years ago. The economy is crap, social media is ruining kids, public schools are going to crap, being a mom is a straight up scam of thankless domestic servitude, and pandemic happened. So I am very glad I never had kids and I know I would have if it wasn't for those pics being shared. You tried to ruin my life but you may have ended up saving it. Thank you to the scum bag who did this to me, whoever you are.

Edit: Thank you so much for all of your kind words of support! It really means a lot to me ❤️

Location: Virginia, United States

Hi all! *Not here to get judged or get told that I deserved it and that I am stupid, I will report all DM's and comments like that* This is very embarrassing and I am shaken up, someone I know was using one of those face search websites and let me know that a lot of porn came up. 100s of results actually. I went to check for myself and I am mortified to say that it is multiple videos and images. In the past I have done videos for pay but taken all of that down and never consented to that being shared. There's also what seems like recordings of me on video calls and whatnot that I did not know were being recorded. The problem is I don't know who shared these and the websites aren't your typical pornhub or Twitter or facebook so I don't know how to take them down or where they are based from. I am scared that since I willingly sold videos nothing can be done about it. I have no idea how to even bring this up with anyone because I am embarrassed. Thanks in advance

-Being more specific, took down all my social media from that time. It wasn't an only fan, pornhub situation more a one on one sharing videos and getting paid for it from men and whatnot (not looking to be judged, I was a broke 18 year old). They all knew that it was not to be shared or posted online and I had a clear disclaimer. Again the issue is that I don't have the social media and messages anymore. The content was filmed outside of Virginia and most likely being distributed outside the country. I don't want something that I thought was private when I was naive at 18 affect my professional life now in my late 20s

UPDATE! Talked to a lawyer, went through and found every single platform and copyright disclaimer. There is also record of who had access to it and already got most websites to take it down by proving copyright infringements! I also have a pretty good idea now who shared them in the first place as well because of them being stupid and trying to log into multiple of my socials and of course it send the verification to my dead email with the location of the attempt. Took lots of help but feeling 1000x better

AGAIN... not here to get hated on or be told I deserved it.

i'm dealing with a revenge porn case and don't know what to do anymore

i (22f) am a victim of revenge porn. my ex boyfriend from two years ago has been sending my nudes to my boyfriend, and people that i know since last week. i went to the police when it first happened and i got a protective order against him.

it happened again today and i went back to the police to tell them that he violated the order. i was told that because he hasn't been served there's nothing that they can do. basically meaning that he can do whatever he wants until he gets caught.

i have court tomorrow. he likely won't show up. but they still can't do anything because it is a civil matter, not criminal. i have filed charges and i'm waiting to hear back from the states attorney to submit evidence.

another thing is he keeps doing this from different accounts via instagram and reddit so the police said that they don't know for sure that its him so when i present this in court tomorrow it'll be my word against his as there is no proof that he's behind these accounts. i know its him because he's the only one who has these pictures and videos of me.

i was hoping that he'd get arrested or be served, but he currently does not have an address so they can't find him. i just want him to stop. is there anyway that i can find him to give to the court tomorrow?

Traumatized!! I got flashed by a man on my college campus

Rant

Hey guys I am an mbbs student. So an unfortunate incident took place on our college campus. Our college is not safe and the security is useless. I was walking behind the hospital building which is the nearest route to go out if you don't have a vehicle and many hostellers take that route and some unknown guy started to unzip his pants and didn't stop even after yelling at him. He went on to remove his pants and put his dick out and started approaching me. I yelled at him and he began to run and I ran behind him. Not single security guard showed up though I was yelling until a few junior boys noticed and went behind him. He ran towards the parking and jumped the wall and escaped. This was at 6:50 pm yesterday. If the security did respond on time he would be caught. The area behind hospital has zero security.

I was having a panic attack right after and someone from the management had the audacity to ask why I was alone and why I took that route and how I shouldn't mention about this to anyone and only then things will get solved.

This wasn't any student but some guy in his 30s. He is either a worker or some random person who has entered campus or a patient's attendant. The walls of our college facing the adjacent road don't even have barbs to prevent people from jumping into the campus. I made sure the Dean and the wardens know about it and have a meeting with them soon.

I am traumatized and I feel super unsafe to even step out to go to the hostel canteen.

Update: Hey guys thank you so much for your support. Necessary changes to be made have been put forward. To increase CCTV and security and to put barbs or glass pieces on the wall of the compound. And to make a note of the cars and any vehicles numbers that enter the hostel or hospital premises. A signed and sealed letter has been submitted to the civil department to make necessary changes. A formal complaint has been filed by the Dean to the police along with the CCTV footage.

Reddit now requires that in order to report revenge porn, the person directly involved in the revenge porn needs to contact reddit. The video I reported was an ex boyfriend breaking into the woman's location where she was naked, and the woman begging him to stop filming and leave, and him refusing.

I sometimes browse subreddits where people are likely to post non-consensual intimate media, and I report them and in a few days I get a report back from reddit saying the post was removed.

Recently I reported a video as described in the title, and got this report back.

Thanks for submitting a report to the Reddit admin team. Before we can respond to this particular report, we need the person who's directly involved to submit a report with more information.

You can direct them to our report form, where they can submit a report from their own account and include more information.

Thanks again for your report, and for looking out for yourself and your fellow redditors. Your reporting helps make Reddit a better, safer, and more welcoming place for everyone.

If you'd like to get a better understanding of Reddit's rules, check out our Rules & Reporting FAQs.

For your reference, here are additional details about your report:

Report Details

Report reason: Non-consensual intimate media Submitted on: 05/02/2022 at 02:03 AM UTC

This was a video uploaded to v.redd.it . So it's on Reddit's servers. I have no idea who was involved.

The video was heart breaking, with the girl begging for the guy to stop. Whoever responded is a piece of shit fucking